# "I must have done something to deserve this."

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## Where it often comes from

The mind seeks explanations for pain, and self-blame can feel easier than randomness. Rumination about past mistakes fuels shame.

## What Scripture teaches

Jesus said of those killed in a tragedy, that they were not worse sinners than others (Luke 13:1–5). He said of the blind man, "Neither this man nor his parents sinned." "The soul who sins is the one who will die," yet "A son will not bear the iniquity of his father." Suffering in a fallen world often comes without a proportionate cause. Believers may repent of sin and be forgiven, but suffering is not a ledger of what we deserve.

> *"Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"* (John 9:3).

## Also see

> "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him" (Ezekiel 18:20).

> "Or those eighteen who were killed when the tower of Siloam collapsed on them: Do you think that they were more sinful than all the others living in Jerusalem?" (Luke 13:4).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

> "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust" (Psalm 103:14).

## Common self-statements

- It is my fault.
- If I had been better, this would not have happened.
- This is what I get.
- I deserve to suffer.
- I brought it on myself.
- God is balancing the scales.

## Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing suffering is either deserved or random.
- Fortune telling: Predicting more consequences.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I deserve it.
- Personalization: Calling myself deserving of suffering.

## Challenging questions

- What specifically do I think I did?
- Would I say a friend deserved the same illness?

- What did Jesus say about suffering and sin?
- What has been forgiven and what do I carry?
- What caused my illness according to my doctors?
- How can I put down self-blame?

## Truth summary

> My suffering is not a measure of what I deserve. Jesus rejects the simple equation between suffering and sin. I can bring real sin to God for forgiveness and let go of self-blame.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Suffering
- Sickness
- Forgiveness
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Divorce

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "I must have done something to deserve this"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"I must have done something to deserve this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What specifically do I think I did?
- ☐ Would I say a friend deserved the same illness?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about suffering and sin?
- ☐ What has been forgiven and what do I carry?
- ☐ What caused my illness according to my doctors?
- ☐ How can I put down self-blame?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Suffering is not always deserved.
- ☐ Jesus rejects the equation.
- ☐ I am forgiven in Christ.
- ☐ God knows my frame.
- ☐ I can put down self-blame.
- ☐ He is with me.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ John 9:3
  *"Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"*
- ☐ Ezekiel 18:20
  *"The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."*
- ☐ Luke 13:4
  *"Or those eighteen who were killed when the tower of Siloam collapsed on them: Do you think that they were more sinful than all the others living in Jerusalem?"*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Self-blame lifted: Each week, note one thought of self-blame you replaced.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  *For example, John 9:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus rejects the simple link between suffering and sin.""*
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).*

- ☐ Write the charge. State what you blame yourself for.
- ☐ Speak to yourself as to a friend. Rewrite it kindly.
- ☐ Confess if needed. Receive forgiveness.
- ☐ Talk with a counselor. Work through guilt.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must have done something to deserve this": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Self-blame lifted |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must have done something to deserve this.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, I search my past for a reason. Free me from false guilt, forgive what is real, and comfort me in my suffering. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*